

Alexa vs Alice: Cultural Perspectives on the Impact of AI

By Idoia Salazar, President and Co-Founder, OdiselA

Artificial Intelligence is already a reality that is evolving in an exponential manner. Its social impact will have an unprecedented relevance that undoubtedly needs to be monitored from now on, without further delay. Even though the international community has turned to this process to establish general and international measures in Ethics and Social Impact of AI, the generalities may be, in this case, not enough. Thus, the cultural perspective, often defined by the geographical situation, is an important factor that must be taken into account when evaluating the social impact of an Artificial Intelligence system. Likewise, the historical-temporal element is a key to prevent possible decontextualization of its application. This course explores why it is important to take into account the cultural, geographical, and temporal aspects of AI, as well as their precise identification, in order to achieve the correct development and implementation of AI systems.

Lecture Transcript

0:00 Hello, welcome everyone. My name is Idoia Salazar, and I'm going to be talking about the different cultural perspectives on the impact of artificial intelligence, Alexa versus Alice, or Alicia, which is Alexa, the occidental bot, versus Alice or Alicia which is a Russian one. First of all, first of all, I would like to introduce myself. My name, as I said, is Idoia Salazar. I am the President and Co-Founder of the Social and Ethical Impact of Artificial Intelligence Observatory, I'm also Co-Director of the Ethics and Responsible Area in OdiselA, the same observatory. I'm also PhD in Journalism, Professor at San Pablo CEU University in Madrid, Spain. And I specialize in ethics of artificial intelligence. I'm a principal investigator in SIMPAIR Research Group, which is the Social Impact of Artificial Intelligence and Robotics Research Group. And I'm an author of different books, which is The Myth of the Algorithm: Tales and truths of Artificial Intelligence (co-authored with Richard Benjamins), The Evolution of Robots: How Artificial Intelligence and Robotics Affect our Future, and The Depths of the Internet: Access Information that Search Engines cannot Find and Discover the Intelligent Future of the Internet. The three of them are written in Spanish. I'm also a founding member of Springer AI and Ethics Journal, a member of the Global AI Ethics Consortium. As you see all my professional life dedicated to study to how technology impacts society, and nowadays, as we know, we live in a global village in which technology is really affecting all the way that we live. And nowadays, we know that artificial intelligence is not something that we see movies, but it is starting to affect many things that we are going to be living in the next years. Actually, nowadays, there are plenty of companies that are already implementing these artificial intelligence systems, in the different services and products in order to make better the different processes, and one way or the other is going to affect our society. We know that we are we are trying through these technologies, we are trying to make the world a little bit smaller. But we have to think that even though we are we are really trying to make this world a little bit smaller, there are some things that are still surviving in each one of the of the countries. There are some things that it's almost impossible to keep aside in order to study this the impact of this technology, which is these multi cultural differences, we really tried with these artificial intelligence technologies to try to make like international code of ethics for example, to have like an just one code, international code of ethics that could make them the main the main topics to be thinking about when we think when we try to see how to quote educate machines in the in these in a way to minimize the negative impact of these technologies. But we are proceeding right now that it is quite difficult to make international code of ethics of artificial intelligence, because every country even though we are really trying through this technology to make life to make it smaller, we are knowing now that is

AI ETHICS

very, very important to pay attention to them with the cultural differences in order to do a good work and to make these artificial intelligence systems to work correctly. Because it is the first thing that we have to think about is these artificial intelligence peculiarities, what has this artificial intelligence that do not have other technologies that were that were that were happening before these artificial intelligence systems? From one side we have the produces from science fiction. Nowhere were just in a very few times, we had a another technologies that which was that which were in in the minds of the people as much as these robots and artificial intelligence agents, some bots because we have even the even the internet a we couldn't even think about something related or something similar to the internet before the internet appeared, but we did have into our minds the vision or just the image of our robot, so far or artificial intelligence system before this artificial intelligence and these robots a- appear.

5:29 We already have these produces from science fiction, it is a fact that in the in the Oriental world has like a different views about these different similarities and different perceptions of these technologies, quite different from the one that we have in the Occidental world. For we will explain, we will go over it a little bit later, but really, this produces science fiction are one of the main things that we need to work about in order to keep going with them with the development of artificial intelligence and in in, in and the impact in society. And then we have another big reality, which is very important to talk about, which is these process inherent to the human now performed by machines with a decision making. Nowadays, just these algorithms are able will be able even better in the future of making decisions and this this is one peculiarity that was just for humans, some years ago, and for some people feel some people really feel very disappointed this very confused when they think about these machines making decisions and that everything these producers plus these processes ensuring to the humans now performed by machines, makes people feel these sorts of view these fears. So, it is very important to keep educating society, keep saying the society that this is not the real things about artificial intelligence that we should keep telling them what is the real what is the reality what's the currently what is happening with this technology and keeping an eye on try to keep aside all of these producers that just lead to confusion into the different societies. As I said before, there is quite different perceptions between the Occidental point of view and the Oriental point of view. Then here we can see different images from Western science fiction movies, like for example, I brought Ex Machina or Terminator. We used to we tend to see in these occidental movies, we tend to see how these artificial intelligence systems or these robots wants to take over humanity or most of them wants to are very autonomous or want to leave aside the humans and stay them as leaders. While there is quite a difference to for example, the Oriental society. For example, in Japan and or China in which they have been racing while they are since they are born with some cartoons even cartoons in which they see these robots as some as a heroes. So, we then we it is it is quite different the perception that these people there in the Oriental world has about these robots and this artificial intelligence, nowadays, these people are using these robots and these artificial intelligence systems to help humans in many in many task. For example, helping old people old people that make that are in hospitals, or maybe just develop different tasks or even a helping some people that do not like to stay with other people to, you know, to feel less alone. And while here again, in the Occidental world, we see how we are many times talking about robots as us things that are going to substitute humans and this kind of of ideas. Okay?

10:00 Where in the Oriental world, they see these more like, today to artificial intelligence systems as some utility to help people in order to improve themselves. While here, in the Occidental world, we see we still, many people keep thinking that robots are going to substitute humans and to leave and think about keeping these decisions just for robots, and offer us because intelligent systems and so humans won't have any chance to, to keep going and stay well, when these artificial intelligence systems will keep developing. So, here we can see one of the typical

AI ETHICS

pitchers in the decision making, while it is very important to have in in in into account, the certificate, these are these cultural difference, it is because we in we depending on the on the place that we leave in which even in which family we have been raised in, you know, depending in so many, many different things that are around every, every person, we think differently. Even when we think about important things. Here you can see a very typical picture. They This is the Tram Dilemma, in which you have in front of that tram, which do not have brakes, it has a brakes failure, you get you this, this tram would do two things, keep straight and in case, these tram keeps going straight, they will be they will be running over five people. And then if this person twisting these sides side of the tram just turned, there will be just one person that would be killed. There is there's no there's no good answer, maybe many of you would choose to, to turn, because there is just one person that would be killed in this in this if you decide this option. But if you sometimes when you think differently, if you introduce new factors, like for example, if that only person is one person of your family, maybe what do you think maybe you would like keep it straight because you know the other person or maybe don't care if if there are five and just one or the other, but if there is one person that you know, maybe you don't, and there's another thing if you turn that means that you are doing a conscious act of, of turning. So maybe you could feel even worse, because you're like making this conscious act of turning instead of just going straight on just do not do anything and run over these five people because you don't do any act really, but in your mind. So, there are many people they have they have been plenty of exercises about these some similar experiments about this. This same example, for example, one is one of the MIT was called the Moral Machine. This Moral Machine was trying to get data from through an example like this through different parts of the of the world to know if they if it was possible to make like, if people from throughout the world could have like same or similar actions or similar decisions about some specific cases. And at the end, they the thought that at the at the end they saw that there was no just one ethical decision, there was no just one point of view about the different situations, but there are many, many depending on the part of the world they were in or maybe in the peculiarities of the person that is specific person or about so many things people were thinking one way or the other even about very important questions. So there is some after everything, there is a fact in in this, this new world that we are going to be living we are living already right now. Which is that we have to learn to live together. Who? Artificial intelligence systems and humans. Why? Because it's going to be like a very important tool in our future, we have to see it as a tool. This is when for example, in the industrial revolution, we needed that machines to improve our strength in when working in the in the different tasks that we have to do we have to do in the fields.

15:25 So, nowadays, we really need artificial intelligence systems to deal with the big amount of inflammation and big data that we have, nowadays, all around us and we will have in our future even more. So we really need artificial intelligence systems in order to improve us mentally, intellectually. We really need it in order to, you know, to live better in in our future. So we really have to learn to live together. So, we need to keep going and to improve this interaction between these robots or these artificial intelligence systems and humans. How are we going to do that? This is that's the question. Why? Because what we just said at the beginning, we have like in the Occidental world we have plenty of producers, plenty, a lot of producers associated with science fiction, and we really need to keep aside all of these producers and start thinking about what the real things about artificial intelligence is, is what the artificial intelligence systems can give us for good and just leave aside all the negative things about the impact of this technology that has plenty of risk also. So, a very good way of starting this interaction in a social level with between these robots, artificial intelligence and humans, it is through the developing it is developing the through the development of the natural language. Nowadays is very, very there are it is that we have like very good level in in natural language investigation and apply to artificial intelligence systems, but we really need to keep thinking about improving these this investigative field about them, the natural

language. Why? Because and it is it is like the key. When the humans are going to see these robots that communicate are able to communicate with them in their same language is going to be very, very good thing and will really help to keep going to to make better this interaction between the robots and the humans, but there is when we think about this, this this improvement in the natural language of these artificial intelligence systems we have to keep into our head thinking about some very important thing. We also have to think about these artificial intelligence systems as a tool, that means that when we communicate, we will keep communicating, when we will be communicating with these machines, it is very important that we that we see them as machines. So, they are some way they are, they are like they are seen as machines and they will be named as a machine as an artificial intelligence systems. So, humans always have to see that they are communicating with machines and not be confused about if they are communicating with a machine or with another person. So, so, guys, when talking about this development or of these natural language into machines, of course, it will be also very important that the cultural context. So, it is it is very important that these chat bots or artificial intelligence systems, which will be chat bots or another devices really have like share the same peculiarities of the people that are living between.

19:57 Okay, so there are there's this another fact is that people from the from for example, United States are different in their ideas than people for example, in Russia. They think differently, they have, they share specific beliefs. So, if you if you learnt a specific quote in United States, their thoughts, quote, must be different than the one that are in, in Russia. In in Russia for example. Why? Because if these people are communicating, if there are people in Russia communicating with their chatbots you might expect another different thing that the people that are, that are in United States for example. Here we have one very important thing to understand the different cultures of the world, which is the language model. This language model is just a theory, which shows that, depending on the depending on the place, the different countries in which in you are, you could be more linear active or multi active or inactive. For example, for example, people in Germany tend less to react to some things while people for example, in Brazil, they're going to react more to different a to be more emotional, you could see how in the red one in the at the top, where you have a countries like for example, America, Argentina, Mexico, Brazil, Chile, or if it's something you have nearby that Italy, Portugal or Spain, the people are similar. Similar characteristics but are very far away from the people in Germany or Switzerland, or for example, people in Japan people in Japan. So, really when these machines will try to communicate to these kinds of people to these people that have specific peculiarities, they really these machines should be should be or the this design their data scientists who are who are developing these specific bots have to think about their cultural, the cultural, the culture of the specific place in which this specific bot is going to be launched in order for the population to understand well them with these machines or had a good interaction with these machines. Here we have another example. This is this is this is an example that was published in a in a in a in a specific report in specific essay, which was from the Dr. Polina Aronson, and the essay was called "Can emotion-regulating tech translate across cultures?" And you can see here a cooperation between the virtual assistant Siri and its Russian equivalent Yandex. In in one of them the user wrote: "I feel sad" and Siri answered: "I wish I had arms so I could give you a hug." Meanwhile, Yandex's version respond to the same question: "Nobody promised you it would be easy." This is really a great example of how different cultures perceive the world without assuming that one is better than another. So, here is the real importance of to study the place of implementation of artificial intelligence systems such as virtual agents, because this fact can be relevant for, for its for its social accept-acceptance. So, this would be our future this is this is our future we our future will have to live together with these machines, as we as we as I said before, and that is that is also a fact. And what we have today to do today is to keep working in the different techniques to to improve the way we are going to live together to improve a way to live together with these machines and to interact with these machines. And it's not a technical problem, sometimes is not a technical

AI ETHICS

problem. And in this case, it is really not only a technical problem. It is some it is a problem of education. Okay. This is even more important than to keep developing the artificial intelligence systems, natural language or whatever. It is a need in our society of improve our education, in the, in this understanding in the understanding of these machines of these artificial intelligence systems in a way of keeping aside all the producers from science fiction, all them things that that are saying many people about what's going to happen in the future and start thinking about today, how to assume what is what is the current situation with this technology? And how are nowadays, these companies implementing this technology into their different services and products and how these artificial intelligence systems that we have today are going to impact nowadays to our society. Our society needs to understand for what these artificial intelligence systems are taking their personal data and what are what are what are they what are going to be doing these artificial intelligence systems with their personal data, for example. It is time to tell them that this is not a matter of just machines taking decisions and overcoming humanity. And there's what they have to understand is that these artificial intelligence systems are going to come to help us in many times in many tasks, to deal with all the data that we have all of our tasks. And it is time also that we understand the real risk of these artificial intelligence systems, we have many, many risks that are very seriously related, for example, with bias in this data or in the different algorithms of artificial intelligence, and many other risks related for example, with privacy and other important things. So, we need to keep educating society in the real advantages and disadvantages of artificial intelligence. Here I have a book that I have written with Richard Benjamins. And this is it is called Myth of the Algorithm. And this is tales and truths about artificial intelligence. And it's in Spanish, but we really try with these to keep educating society in what is the reality about artificial intelligence systems and forget about these producers and it's written in a very understandable language so everybody, not only scientists, everybody, every people, in the street no matter in which area is these people is could understand what the reality about this technology is. And also, that is why I created this observatory for the ethical answers and impact of artificial intelligence, main of it, it is to educate society. So they get the basis in which they will in which they feel well, in order to grow in this new world of, of living together with these machines in harmony. Thank you very much for everything. And have a good day.